

“The Olympics remain the most compelling search for excellence that exists in sport, and maybe in life itself.”

Dawn Fraser

Australian swimmer, and three-time winner at the Games

Info2008—a wireless intranet system that’s made available to all media personnel and everyone involved in the Games. It’s already impressive that this huge repository of information available to anyone with the right clearance at the click of a button, but what’s more impressive is that it’s available wirelessly, in multiple languages, and is always updated to ensure up-to-the-second freshness of information. There’s so much more we could give you in terms of details, but we’d have to span it over three or four issues of *Digit*. Suffice to say, it’s mind boggling the complexity of the technology systems that AO and their partners manage.

To give you an idea, all of these systems have undergone roughly 2 lakh hours of testing, to ensure that there are no glitches or bugs!

For Beijing 2008, some of the companies AO is partnering with are Lenovo (all hardware—servers and desktops), Omega (time keeping, scoring and providing results at the venues), Panasonic (all audio visual equipment), Kodak (everything imaging related) and Samsung (wireless communication equipment).

Now we’re hardware junkies, so when we found out that Lenovo was providing hardware, we just had to find out more...

Olympic-grade Hardware

We spoke to Leon Xie, the Director of Olympic Sponsorship and Deputy General Manager, Olympic Business Department, at Lenovo (try saying *that* in one breath!).

d How much equipment or hardware, exactly, are we talking of here?

Xie: Over 30,000 pieces of Lenovo hardware are being used at the Games. That’s 12,000 desktop PCs, 10,000 17-inch flat panel displays, 2,000 15-inch touch screen displays, 2,000 desktop printers, 800 notebook computers, 700 servers, and 5,000 “showcase models”. (Showcase models are used in Internet lounges and sponsor partner programs.



Leon Xie, the Director of Olympic Sponsorship and Deputy General Manager, Olympic Business Department—Lenovo

d Wow! So how much does all that equipment that you’re using cost?

Xie: We do not disclose financial terms of our sponsorships.

d Fair enough. What sort of planning goes into a humungous project like this?

Xie: Over the past year, more than 20,000 pieces of Lenovo equipment have been put to the test. Each piece of equipment was configured for the particular sport or system it would be used in during the Games. Next came the actual “in the field” testing at the Good Luck Beijing athletic competitions. These test events were an arduous year-long process that tested all aspects of the hardware in actual sports events to make sure everything worked properly for the Games.

The tests ended only weeks ago in June. Lenovo’s computing systems supporting the Games were tested at 42 separate events, including Chinese volleyball club tournaments, World Cup qualifying matches, the Beijing International Marathon and International Tennis Federation events. The testing phase was vital because implementation of the complex Games computer infrastructure will take place literally overnight. The equipment used at outdoor competition venues was specially selected to withstand the high temperatures, dust and humidity of Beijing’s summer.

The next and final preparatory phase consisted of two technical rehearsals, conducted by BOCOG and involving all technology partners. The final rehearsal, which took place June 10-12, was an all-hands event. Lenovo and all the partners and their technician teams participated as BOCOG, put the teams through a series of real-life scenarios designed to prepare the entire support team for unexpected emergencies.

d So how many venues was all this done in? And what equipment was field tested?

Xie: The physical equipment supporting the Olympic Games and the thousands of personnel who oversee it participated in “Technical Rehearsal 2”. The event simulated three of the busiest days at the Games, implementing all the technology and looking for anything that could possibly go wrong.

The rehearsal forced participants to practice managing an array of potential problems and scenarios—missing equipment, slashed cables, security breaches, power outages, etc. The purpose was to ensure the entire team is ready for any and every kind of problem and challenge they might face during the Games.

A total of 35 Olympic venues across 7 Olympic cities (including equestrian venues in Hong Kong) were involved. Nearly 95 per cent of Lenovo’s computing equipment at every venue was deployed over the three days of intensive